

Food Literacy Through Advertising Analysis

Introduction

In this lesson, students examine the less obvious methods advertisers use to reach consumers, with a particular focus on how food and beverage brands use "soft sell" advertising to shape how teens think about nutrition and growth. Students first learn to tell soft sell ads (which build a feeling about a brand) apart from hard sell ads (which make direct claims about a product). They then apply this thinking specifically to food marketing, learning how to separate a brand's feeling from a food's actual nutritional value, and how to find and trust credible sources of nutrition information instead.

Learning Objectives

1. Explain that the purpose of advertising is to get you to like or buy something
 2. Recognize that advertising uses different techniques and appeals for different products
 3. Identify how advertisers use different media, approaches, and techniques to reach different audiences
 4. Find, identify, and analyze examples of "soft sell" advertising techniques
 5. Communicate your findings to the class
 6. Identify credible sources for nutritional information (Alberta PDE8 curriculum outcome)
 7. Explore ways nutrition supports growth and development (Alberta PDE8 curriculum outcome)
-

What Is Advertising Actually Trying to Do?

Before students can spot a soft sell ad, they need to be clear on what all advertising is for in the first place: getting someone to like or buy something. This section resets that foundation before moving into the subtler techniques.

Class Discussion: The Purpose of Advertising

Open with the question: *What is the purpose of advertising?* Let students discuss for a few minutes, making sure the idea surfaces that ads exist to sell products or services — even when they don't look like a sales pitch.

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads shape feelings, not facts

- Use music, colour, and social scenes
- Link products to comfort, success, or trust
- Hard sell ads state claims directly

Hard Sell vs. Soft Sell

Introduce the distinction: a *hard sell* ad makes direct claims about a product (price, features, "buy now"). A *soft sell* ad makes people know and like a *brand* without saying much about the product at all.

Key Points:

- Hard sell prompts quick action
- Uses direct claims and offers
- Soft sell builds trust and image
- Shapes memory before product details

Quiz

A food advertisement showing bright colours, upbeat music, and friends laughing together is an example of a soft sell technique because it subtly creates a positive mood instead of making direct claims about the product's nutrition.

Answer: True

Reading Soft Sell Ads

This section walks students through the four core soft-selling techniques using the original handout examples, building the analytical vocabulary they'll need before applying it to food marketing specifically.

What Do These Ads Say About the Product? About the Brand?

Distribute the *Soft Sell Ads* handout. Ask what each ad says about the *product* itself (very little, in every case — students may not even recognize the Instagram post as an ad without prior brand familiarity). Then ask what each ad says about the *brand*: Vaio computers are cool (James Bond uses them), Item is fun, Doritos is progressive, Lait D'Homme is cheeky.

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads influence feelings, not facts
- They use music, light, and imagery

- Ads create warmth, energy, and connection
- Focus on emotional message, not claims

The Four Soft-Sell Techniques

Have students turn the handout over and read through the four techniques:

- **Product placement** — paying to have a product featured in a show, movie, or game
- **Endorsement** — paying a real person to be associated with a product
- **Identity and emotion** — connecting a brand to something important to the audience's identity or emotions
- **Parody** — flattering the audience by poking fun at other ad techniques

Key Points:

- Hard sell ads use direct, clear claims
- They often include prices and urgency
- Soft sell ads use emotion and suggestion
- Soft sell builds brand trust and lifestyle appeal

Quiz

In food advertising, a hard sell usually hints at a lifestyle or feeling without giving clear product facts, while a soft sell uses direct claims like prices or “buy now.”

Answer: False

Identifying Credible Sources for Nutritional Information

Soft sell ads work partly because they replace facts with feeling — which makes it easy for a brand's *personality* to stand in for real nutritional information. This section teaches students how to tell the difference between a brand telling a story and a source giving them accurate, evidence-based nutrition guidance.

Brand Voice vs. Credible Source

Discuss: when a snack or drink brand's ad or social account talks about “fueling your body” or “clean ingredients,” is that a nutrition claim from a credible source, or a marketing message? Introduce the idea that a brand's own marketing (packaging, ads, sponsored influencer posts) is never a neutral source of nutrition information, even when it sounds scientific.

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads create a feeling, not facts
- They use stories, music, and celebrities
- Food is shown as fun or comforting
- They suggest benefits with vague hints

What Makes a Source Credible?

Introduce criteria students can use to judge any nutrition claim or source:

- Is it produced by a recognized health authority or a registered/regulated professional (e.g., Health Canada, a registered dietitian, a public health unit)?
- Is it free of a commercial motive to sell a specific product?
- Is it consistent with other credible sources, rather than a lone outlier claim?
- Does it cite evidence rather than testimonials or before/after stories?

Key Points:

- Hard sell uses direct buying reasons
- Soft sell feels less pushy
- Hard sell works quickly with facts
- Soft sell shapes feelings and habits

Practice: Sorting Sources

In pairs, give students a mixed set of nutrition claims (some from public health sources, some from brand ads, some from social media influencers) and have them sort each into "credible source," "brand marketing," or "unclear — needs more checking."

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads link food to moods
- Lifestyle images shape food expectations
- Ads can make unhealthy food seem normal
- Visuals influence judgment before nutrition facts

Quiz

A soft sell food advertisement usually relies on feelings, images, or a short story—such as happy friends or bright colours—rather than direct claims like low price or extra protein, which are more typical of a hard sell ad.

Answer: True

How Food Marketing Connects to Growth and Development

This section links the media-literacy skills from Sections 1–3 to the practical question of why accurate nutrition information matters at this age: adolescence is a period of rapid physical and cognitive growth, and food marketing is deliberately aimed at teens during exactly this window.

Why Nutrition Matters More During the Teen Years

Briefly explain that adolescence involves a growth spurt and significant physical and brain development, which increases the body's need for adequate, balanced nutrition (protein, iron, calcium, and overall energy intake, among other things). This is why teens are such a heavily targeted advertising audience for food and beverage brands.

Key Points:

- Credible nutrition sources are trustworthy and well made
- Check the creator, source, date, and evidence
- Use trusted health groups and Nutrition Facts labels
- Compare claims with sugar, fibre, and serving size

Spotting Soft Sell in Food & Drink Marketing

Return to the four techniques from Section 2, but now applied specifically to food and beverage brands: a sports drink using an athlete endorsement, a cereal using a cartoon mascot placement, a snack brand's "identity" ad tied to friendship or belonging, or a "healthy soda" brand parodying diet-culture advertising.

Key Points:

- Test soft-sell claims against nutrition facts
- Check ingredients and trusted health sources
- Healthy image may not match nutrition
- High sugar or low protein is concerning

Feeling vs. Fact Check

As a quick group activity, take one food or drink ad from 4.2 and have students identify (a) what feeling the ad is selling, and (b) what a credible source would actually say about that product's nutritional role, using the criteria from Section 3.2.

Key Points:

- Carbohydrates provide energy
- Protein supports growth and repair

- Vitamins and minerals aid body function
- Check labels and serving sizes carefully

Quiz

A Nutrition Facts table and ingredient list are more credible sources than a food advertisement's claims when you want to check whether a product is actually healthy and supports growth and development.

Answer: True

Activity — Alternate Ad Audit (Nutrition Edition)

Now that students can name the four soft-sell techniques and know how to check a claim against a credible source, this activity has them put both skills to work independently. Working in groups, students go out and find real examples in the wild, analyze them using the same questions from Sections 1–4, and — for the first time — check a food-related ad's impression against an actual credible nutrition source. This is where the lesson moves from recognizing techniques to applying them critically.

Group Assignment

Divide the class into four groups (or eight, depending on class size). Assign each group one of the four soft-selling techniques (product placement, endorsement, identity appeal, parody). Each group finds **four ads** using their technique — at least one of which must be for a food, beverage, or supplement product.

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads sell feelings, not facts
- They show lifestyle, comfort, and belonging
- Images create trust and mood
- Words like “fresh” build appeal

Analysis Questions

For each ad, students answer:

- Explain how this ad uses this technique.
- How does this ad make you think or feel about the brand?
- What audience do you think this ad is aimed at? How do you know?

- Why do you think this brand chose a soft-selling approach for this ad, and why was it a good choice to reach this audience?
- Does the ad make any nutrition-related claim or impression? Where could you check that claim against a credible source, and does the credible source agree with the impression the ad gives?

Key Points:

- Hard sell ads are direct and obvious
- They use clear, urgent claims
- Soft sell ads create mood and emotion
- Brands choose hard sell for quick sales

Presenting Findings

Groups present their findings to the class, including their nutrition source comparison where applicable.

Marking criteria:

- Understanding of how and why advertisers use soft sell techniques
- Ability to find and identify ads that use a particular technique
- Ability to analyze how and why a technique is used
- Ability to distinguish a brand's marketing message from a credible nutritional source
- Ability to communicate findings to the class

Key Points:

- Soft sell ads influence choices early
- Music, colors, and settings shape feelings
- Packaging can imply health or trust
- Signals can drive desire before labels

Quiz

A food ad that shows a laughing family in a bright kitchen and uses words like “fresh” or “made for good moments” is using a hard sell technique because it gives clear nutrition facts.

Answer: False

Summary

Summary & Key Takeaways

You now understand that advertising is never neutral — even ads that make no claims about a product at all are still working to build a feeling about a brand, and food and beverage marketing is no exception. You can name the four soft-sell techniques, tell a brand's marketing voice apart from a credible nutrition source, and explain why teens are such a heavily targeted audience during a period of significant growth and development.

- Advertising's core purpose is always to get someone to like or buy something — even when it doesn't look like a traditional ad.
- Soft sell ads build a feeling about a brand rather than making claims about a product, using product placement, endorsement, identity/emotion, or parody.
- A brand's own marketing is never a neutral source of nutrition information, no matter how scientific or wellness-focused it sounds.
- Credible nutrition sources are produced by recognized health authorities or regulated professionals, are free of a commercial motive, and are consistent with other trustworthy sources.
- Adolescence is a period of significant physical and cognitive growth, which is exactly why teens are such a heavily targeted audience for food and beverage advertising — and exactly why being able to check marketing claims against credible sources matters.
- Media-literate consumers can separate the feeling an ad sells from the facts a credible source provides — for food marketing just as much as any other product.